



Karan Pillai

karanpillai.m@thehindu.co.in

Chess may be one of the ultimate solo sports, but when played as a team game, everything changes. The loneliness is replaced by camaraderie, the pressure is shared, and every move is made with a common goal in mind.

At the 2025 World Rapid and Blitz Team Championships, Team MGD1 demonstrated how a team setup brings a different kind of vibe to chess tournaments.

Even though the participating teams featured players of multiple nationalities, MGD1 was, in many ways, quintessentially Indian. Of the nine players in total, seven were from the country — Arjun Erigaisi, Pentala

Harikrishna, Atharva Tayade, Pranav Venkatesh, Leon Mendonca, Hariharan Raghavan, and non-playing captain Srinath Narayanan. The two overseas players were David Anton Guijarro from Spain and Stavroula Tsolakidou from Greece.

The team is the eponymous flagship of a Pune-based firm that scouts and manages chess talent from across the country. It has delivered several strong performances in recent years, finishing fourth in the 2023 Pro Chess League and securing bronze and silver in the Rapid and Blitz legs of the last two editions of the Team Championships.

Seeded sixth at the start of this year's edition, the team finished with 21 points from 12 Rapid rounds to become the first Indian-sponsored side to win a title at the tournament.